With the collapse of Chinese authority over Tibet in 1912, the scenario was to undergo a major change. At the time, the thirteenth Dalai Lama was in exile in India and he immediately began to make preparations to return to Lhasa. The last of the Chinese still holding out were granted free passage and allowed to return home via Calcutta. After the Dalai Lama's return to the Tibetan capital via Yatung in January 1913, he issued what the Tibetans regarded as an unambiguous declaration of independence.

To further underline the Dalai Lama's determination to fully separate from China, the Tibetans signed a treaty with Russian-dominated Mongolia that recognized each other's independence. The Tibet-Mongol Treaty was one of the contemporary factors that indicated that the changing equation between the Tibetans and the Chinese required new international agreements. This resulted in the Simla Convention of 1914.

However, at that stage, in keeping with past British policy, it was felt that for the convention to have any meaning, China had to be a party to it. There were primarily two objectives of the convention: the first was to settle the artificial concept of an 'Inner' and 'Outer' Tibet. The second, which did not involve China directly, would be the settlement boundary between British India and Tibet.

The British recognized that they could not possibly come to Tibet's aid in the event of the Chinese deciding to flex their military muscle. It was therefore necessary for them to have two platforms on either side of Bhutan from where they could influence events—the Chumbi Valley to the west and Tawang in the east. Accordingly, there were protracted discussions pertaining to the threat from China between Sir Charles Bell who was assisting Henry McMahon, the British foreign secretary, and the Lonchen Shatra.

SIMLA CONVENTION, 1914, AND ITS AFTERMATH

Strangely, the British government went to great lengths to keep the proceedings of the Simla Convention of 1914 under wraps. So much so that even the Assam government was kept in the dark as to what was decided as the final frontiers of India. The explanation perhaps lay in the earlier 1907 Anglo-Russian Convention. The agreement with Russians had stipulated that both the British and the Russians acknowledge Chinese suzerainty over Tibet and that neither side could sign an independent treaty with the Tibetans. Article II of the section titled 'Arrangement Concerning Thibet'